Celebrate

Fourth Sunday of Advent

December 21, 2025

First Church

Celebrate Service 11 AM - January 4, 2026

GATHERING

WELCOME

Pastor Duane Carlisle

Song

"Peace Has Come"

CALL TO WORSHIP

L: In the dark of morning,

P: the stars still shine.

L: In the depth of winter,

P: the birds still climb.

L: At the start of the year,

tender and new,

P: God is here.

God is near.

L: Do not rest in your fear.

P: God is here.

L: So like the stars and the birds,

P: Let us worship holy God.

GOSPEL READING

Matthew 2:1-12, 16-18

After Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea, during the time of King Herod, Magi from the east came to Jerusalem and asked, “Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him.”

When King Herod heard this he was disturbed, and all Jerusalem with him. When he had called together all the people’s chief priests and teachers of the law, he asked them where the Messiah was to be born. “In Bethlehem in Judea,” they replied, “for this is what the prophet has written:

“‘But you, Bethlehem, in the land of Judah,

are by no means least among the rulers of Judah;

for out of you will come a ruler

who will shepherd my people Israel.'"

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Then Herod called the Magi secretly and found out from them the exact time the star had appeared. He sent them to Bethlehem and said, "Go and search carefully for the child. As soon as you find him, report to me, so that I too may go and worship him."

After they had heard the king, they went on their way, and the star they had seen when it rose went ahead of them until it stopped over the place where the child was. When they saw the star, they were overjoyed. On coming to the house, they saw the child with his mother Mary, and they bowed down and worshiped him. Then they opened their treasures and presented him with gifts of gold, frankincense and myrrh. And having been warned in a dream not to go back to Herod, they returned to their country by another route.

When Herod realized that he had been outwitted by the Magi, he was furious, and he gave orders to kill all the boys in Bethlehem and its vicinity who were two years old and under, in accordance with the time he had learned from the Magi. Then what was said through the prophet Jeremiah was fulfilled:

"A voice is heard in Ramah,

weeping and great mourning,

Rachel weeping for her children

and refusing to be comforted,

because they are no more."

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weeping and great mourning,

Rachel weeping for her children

and refusing to be comforted,

because they are no more."

Song

"Light Of The World"

OPENING PRAYER

God of the Stars,
like the magi,
we come to this place searching for you.
So today, just like every day,
we ask that you would remove any barricades that keep us from your Spirit.
Clear out the distractions.
Wipe away the doubt.
Open up our hearts,
and speak to us through these ancient words.
And as you do,
we will keep walking.
As you do,
we will move toward you.
With hope we pray,
amen.

PROCLAIMING

MESSAGE TO YOUNG DISCIPLES

SERMON

Fear Doesn't Stop Us

RESPONDING

PASTORAL PRAYER

The Lord's Prayer

Our Father, who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, thy will be done on earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil. For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, forever. Amen.

MOMENT OF GENEROSITY

THE PEACE

SENDING FORTH

Song

"A Christmas Hymn (To The Tune Of "Come Thou Fount")"

BENEDICTION

POSTLUDE

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